

# Kite Runners

A forensic scientist and an auditor join hands to preserve the dying art of kite making and to re-kindle the popularity of an age-old pastime



**DADA AND SEHGAL  
WITH THEIR  
COLOURFUL WORKS**

SANJAY KUMAR

| By Arvind Chhabra |

It looks like a tiny bindi a woman might fancy on her forehead. In reality, the incredibly tiny 0.16 x 0.15 cm bindi-like thing is a proper kite with a frame. The proud maker of the kite, Devinder Singh Sehgal, 49, is a forensic scientist for whom making kites of weird sizes and shapes is a passion. Sehgal and his kite-flying partner Manmohan Dada, 58, a senior audit officer with the Central Government, have several interesting achievements to their credit. Sehgal holds a world record for making the smallest kite and participated in the fifth miniature kite contest organised by the Drachen Foundation that disseminates information on kites. Sehgal's name figured in the *Limca Book of Records* for passing eight kites through the eye of a .003-inch needle. "I bettered that record to 13 kites but the record book now no longer acknowledges miniature feats," he says.

What started as a hobby during childhood became a passion when they realised that they could start disseminating social messages through their kites. It was then that they started making kites as well. Participating in

competitions also helped. "The Chinese and Koreans make good quality waterproof stuff while we are way behind them," says Dada.

They lament that kite-flying is losing its sheen in cities though people still fly kites in towns on Basant Panchmi and Makar Sankranti. "Parents should encourage their kids to fly kites for an hour daily instead of allowing them to watch television. Not only does it improve eyesight but is a great stressbuster too," reasons Sehgal who holds a doctorate in chemistry. The two, however, want the Government to do more for the sport. With an experience of 20 years behind them, they are invited as judges at competitions and relish giving tips to youngsters.

The two participate in all possible events in and around Chandigarh to spread awareness on water conservation, fighting terror, urging donations or condemning female foeticide. The US Environment Protection Agency has commended Sehgal's efforts on climate change and the Punjab Government has awarded him for his contribution in the field of art. ■